

Music HL/SL

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Grade boundaries

This DP/CP N22 subject report contains overall subject boundaries only, unlike previous reports where component boundaries were also published; component boundaries for this session are available in IBIS. The IB advises schools not to use component boundaries for this session as direct indicators of academic standards for future exam preparation because they have been set in response to the particular needs of the N22 cohort. Two significant conditions which do not normally feature in grade boundary setting have had to be satisfied during the boundary setting for the N22 session: the need to apply reasonable standards to adjusted assessment models for students who have restricted access to learning during the COVID pandemic and the need to maintain parity with students who undertook the non-examination route.

Higher level overall

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 10	11 - 22	23 - 36	37 - 50	51 - 64	65 - 78	79 - 100

Standard level overall

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 8	9 - 17	18 - 29	30 - 44	45 - 60	61 - 76	77 - 100

Higher level and standard level experimenting with music

The range and suitability of the work submitted

The work submitted covered a broad range of marks, but still with a small number achieving the very highest. Overall, there seemed to be a slightly greater understanding of the experimental process. Experimenting progressively with one stimulus through three experiments produced some of the most effective work.

Creating experiments:

Stylistically, experimenting in area of inquiry (AOI) 4 to produce electronic dance music was probably the most common, after that, work in jazz styles, followed by rock and western art music in about equal measure

It was quite common for a candidate to present one or two compositions with a midi demo and to finish with something created at a digital audio workstation (DAW).

Several candidates chose to create music in a certain style, without citing any particular stimulus. Although this might comply with the assessment task, it is difficult for examiners to evaluate the development of musical ideas from source material (descriptor from criterion B) in creations that are wholly original.

Performing experiments:

Experiments in performing were generally mostly appropriate to the task, but there were problems in finding ways to be experimental in performance, particularly for those candidates who have not been playing their instruments for very long.

Some well-structured experiments, supported by interesting and relevant research, were received. Experimentation projects in performing were sometimes at the intersection with experimentation in creation: changing the harmony, adding a bass line.

A number of candidates presented performance preparation excerpts rather than experimentation in performance.

Candidate performance against each criterion

Work tended to be more "experimental" in Creating than in Performing.

Criterion A

The presentation of rationales is inconsistent, with many candidates merely presenting an introductory paragraph stating the music they are going to work with.

Evidence of research was not always present, and some candidates limited themselves to naming the pieces they were going to work with, rather than giving a reference. Given the word limit, the higher scorers were those who managed to show, concisely that some research had been done, and that this information was providing an input to the experimentation, stating the source and various stimuli, with clear references.

Although rationales were quite often purposeful, in general more justification would have helped.

The inclusion of AOI and context was generally observed. About half of the candidates merely mentioned it without giving some explanation. The understanding of "local" remains a problem, with many thinking

it means “unfamiliar”. More candidates are now referring to the AOI and context in their rationale, but there is often little real justification for the choice, and it is rarely referred to again in the commentary on each experiment.

In commentaries the use of screenshots from music technology applications was very common, and there was possibly an overuse of this, as many of the images didn’t communicate very much. Candidates who presented more conventional creations scored better when making use of musical examples in their commentaries, and several lower scorers would have done better with the simple inclusion of a few examples which would have moved their presentation of the process from an outline to a description.

Justification does not appear understood yet is of the essence for higher marks. Most reports outlined or described the experimentation. A good number of candidates lacked technical vocabulary and understanding and struggled to identify and articulate musical aspects.

Criterion B

As stated above, one of the main difficulties for examiners in arriving at a mark for criterion B was being able to evaluate the development of musical ideas. Candidates who started out with a project to write music in a certain style, rather than experiment with stimulus material, rarely went beyond “recreating”.

Higher scorers in B managed to transform material through experimentation that lead to clearly discernible decision making, resulting in transformation of materials and the creation of something new, with an individual voice.

Criterion C

Regarding rationale and research, as criterion A, but it was clear that many candidates were not accustomed to the idea of experimenting with their instruments, having probably spent their years of study learning to recreate as faithfully as possible the music set in front of them.

There were some good examples of trying out, as examples, different articulations, dynamics, phrasings. These scored better when they were justified/prompted by research and went beyond adhering to the immediate requirements of the score.

Bibliographies for weaker candidates were often very thin for the performing, and there was a lack of referencing of written and recorded pieces of music.

Several candidates interpreted the experimental process as 'learning a new skill' and then providing a diary-like account.

Criterion D

It was noticeable that those achieving the higher marks in criterion D were those who had more experience in playing their chosen instruments. Sometimes marks in D were lower than C because whereas the process had been well justified and set out, the audio result was limited, with musical decisions not being particularly discernible.

Some candidates produced extremely mature, sophisticated performances but there were many examples of quite safe performances that did little audible experimentation. Some candidates showed a good level of performance ability although their work not always tended to not be very experimental, relying simply on their skill levels.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future candidates

More attention could be paid to the guide.

Candidates should not only include their choice of AOI and context, but these should be justified and referred to in the written text.

Scores should include basic details such as clefs, key signatures and which instruments are playing.

Screen shots of, for example, DAWs need explanation, too many are just images with little or no explanation.

All media used should be referenced, including pieces of musical source material; bibliographies should be comprehensive and are a good indication of the amount and level of depth of the candidate's research.

Ensure candidates convey the nature of the experiments and the motivation, providing an explanation is essential. Many candidates list decisions or information on the stimulus, yet often do not address the "why" of its selection (musically speaking). What are they after? What prompts them to experiment? Additionally, what does the experiment consist of? how do they shape their decisions and test/evaluate results? This should be the backbone of the rationale.

Remember that examiners, in creating experiments, are looking to reward the shaping and development of actual musical ideas, not just the recreation of a genre.

In performing experiments it is not necessary to be radical, (although this can be interesting) but to show that experimenting decisions have been applied to the performance, and that the effect is audible, and has been evaluated by the candidate.

Higher level and standard level exploring music in context

The range and suitability of the work submitted

The limitations that Covid imposed on teaching and the innovative requirements of the new curriculum seem to have influenced some work in this November 2022 session. The number of schools and their candidates that misunderstood the requirements was high. This is more pronounced in the practical exercises of the component (the creating exercise and especially the performed adaptation). At the same time, there were several candidates that took advantage of the freedom to explore cultures and pieces and discovered interesting musical elements they put to use in their creations and adaptations.

Candidate performance against each criterion

As stated above, there were some compelling submissions. However, this section will focus on describing areas that need attention from supervisors and candidates. In the section “Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future candidates” we will make a brief analysis of those cases where candidates reached high marks to be used as examples for subsequent sessions.

Criterion A

Unfortunately, several candidates did not report areas of inquiry (AOI) or contexts while other candidates merely listed these elements without offering any justification for selecting the areas of investigation or contexts. In other cases areas of inquiry were listed and an attempt to justify AOI was provided, but the justification was not convincing. The most typical case was of music not composed for a film but used in films and justified as AOI 3. For instance, a film using music from Bach that was not composed for the film as opposed to music from Star Wars where the composer purposefully created music to support the plot and the images on the screen. In other cases, candidates selected music that was created for the dramatic impact such as ballet pieces. However, in their analysis, they did not connect the music to that reason which made them correctly classify it as AOI 3. In these cases, candidates described musical elements that were not directly supporting the dramatic effect.

In terms of evidence, many candidates presented notated examples that were not specifically representing anything but were used more as decoration. For instance, the front pages of the compositions without any specific analysis to justify them.

While some audio examples supported the arguments, others were too generalized. For instance, candidates stated “...in this example, you will find contrasting dynamics...” and provided a 40-second example that was too imprecise to be a useful example. In cases like this, the person doing the analysis is the examiner and not the candidate. For evidence to be effective, it needs to point out in a very specific way to a very specific spot.

On the other side of the spectrum, several candidates went well beyond the limit of space for illustration and words. Please remember that these limits are 2400 words and 5 pages of illustrations. Examiners must not read beyond the permitted maximums. This impacted those responses that had sections 2 (statement on the creating exercise) and 3 (statement on the performed adaptation) beyond the 2400 words and, as a result, these sections were not able to be taken into consideration.

Another element is the need to add references to the claims made. This is a standard academic paper and therefore including references is not optional.

Criterion B1

Some candidates explored 6-8 pieces, which created diversity and breadth in the submission. However, unfortunately the depth of the information provided about these pieces was often shallow. There is a balance to be established between the number of pieces selected, the diversity, the breadth, and the depth of the musical research.

Candidates should stay away from providing anecdotal information about composers. As implied above, with a limit of 2400 words, the selection of information presented needs to be effective. Please provide only the information that is relevant and purposeful. Telling that a composer started studying music at 4 years of age might not be as relevant as explaining the musical characteristic of the composer's style.

Criterion B2

The objective of this component is that candidates explore musical materials and then, with the knowledge acquired, they create practical exercises. This rather simple scheme is not always followed. Several candidates create practical exercises without any connection to the exploration made in section 1. At times, candidates create practical exercises on pieces not explored at all. In some cases, pieces are simply listed in sections 2 and 3 without any exploration. In these situations, there is no implication possible.

Criterion C1

A musical element found in a piece is not necessarily a convention. A symphony written in A major does not mean that all symphonies are written in A major. A Mexican mariachi song that uses a saxophone does not imply that a saxophone is part of this style. To determine what is a real convention of a style there is a need to explore many examples representative of the style. Unfortunately, some candidates explore one piece and believe that all elements found in the piece are conventions. For example, let us pretend that a candidate is interested in the 1st Vienna School style, more concretely, the style of Mozart. Let us pretend that the candidate selects the piece A Musical Joke (Ein musikalischer Spaß) K 522. In this piece, Mozart makes a joke of the classical style by composing music that goes against its conventions. For instance, he uses parallel fifths, dissonances, whole tone scales, incorrect keys in sonata form, errors in fugato. If a candidate explores only this piece by Mozart, the candidate will believe that all the compositional elements used by Mozart are conventions of the style. Only after analyzing many compositions of Mozart and the 1st Vienna School, a candidate is capable to realize that the musical elements used in Ein musikalischer Spaß are satirical. This example helps to illustrate what happens to many candidates. They explore only one piece and believe that everything that is in that piece is a convention. They are unable to determine if the piece explored is hybrid or not. If it is a representative example of the style or not. More specifically, from all the musical elements explored, they are unable to determine which are specific to that style or common to many styles. Therefore, the advice is to do profound research to be able to establish what the conventions of a style are. This is a necessary step if a candidate wants to present a creation that uses authentic conventions. Once the conventions have been identified, the candidate is in a better position to apply them to the creation.

Criterion C2

This is probably the area that was the most elusive to candidates and teachers. Several issues occurred. Some candidates understood the task backward. For instance, if the convention explored was from the jazz style, they created arrangements where they took the jazz piece and arranged it in salsa style. Here

there are two errors, 1) the piece is not supposed to be an arrangement, and 2) the idea is to 'acquire' the performance practices of Jazz and not to transform them into salsa.

Another problem caused by a misunderstanding of the task was the lack of discussion of performance practices. Some candidates discussed elements that do not necessarily relate to the performance practices. For instance, candidates stated that in their adaptation they used the same meter or the same key as the stimulus. However, these elements do not relate to performance practices. A sonata for violin by Mozart could be in 4/4 as could a tango. The question is how a tango violinist plays the instrument differently from the same violinist playing Mozart's sonata. This element of performance practices is difficult to grasp for candidates. Especially when the candidate still needs to demonstrate the knowledge acquired by adapting the stimulus to the candidate's instrument.

Several candidates did not upload the stimulus (upload no. 2) as required in the music guide. In other cases, candidates used a different stimulus from that explored in section 1.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future candidates

Criterion A

Candidates who earned high marks in this criterion justified their AOIs and analyzed elements of music that related to them. For instance, if a candidate selects film music, the candidate must focus on the musical elements that support the images. If a candidate selects electronic music, naming the key or the tonality does not explain the AOI4 elements. The candidate should instead focus on the elements that make the piece music technology.

The evidence presented should be focused on and relevant to the points being made, not decorative. An image of Beethoven or Lady Gaga does not add to the arguments. An illustration of a notated example showing a canonic passage could be more effective to make a point. Notated examples offer a way to convey concise information that could save candidates many words. While it is challenging to use notated evidence in pop music and traditional music, in most western art music it is possible to find scores

The use of audio evidence is an option that can be effective provided that the excerpt is focused on the point being made and not of a length that prevents the listener from understanding the argument.

Criterion B1

Candidates who got high marks in this criterion presented relevant findings. Some other candidates gave the impression of providing the first lines of the articles consulted. At times these candidates referred to anecdotal facts of the composers. Candidates need to demonstrate a good understanding of the topic by selecting its relevant aspects.

It is advised that candidates provide information relevant to the style and information that will determine the conventions that will be used in the practical exercises.

Criterion B2

Candidates with high marks in this criterion were strategically connecting the research to the practical exercise. That is, not to take the component as a series of isolated tasks that do not relate to each other.

Criterion C1

A convention could be understood as a series of elements that are common to a series of pieces and create a style. Not all the musical elements present in a piece are part of the conventions. The use of 4/4 or G

major in a Baroque piece is not part of a convention. The use of figured bass in a Baroque piece is a convention. When candidates select elements to be used in their creations, they need to ensure that these elements are part of the set of conventions of a style. This can only be done through deep research of the style.

Criterion C2

This criterion should be understood in similar terms to C1. Performance practices are specific ways to play music within a given style. In other words, a given melody should not be played the same if the composer is Vivaldi or Brahms. If the music is traditional Celtic music, or if is a Tango. Each style has specific performance practices. The objective of this exercise is that candidates become acquainted with performance practices unknown to them and they attempt to incorporate them with their instruments. For instance, a candidate exploring and becoming familiar with the violin performance practices in tango (strong accents, staccatos, tremolos, pizzicatos, fast glissandos, playing behind the bridge), would attempt to adapt a tango with a flute. This would require the use of extended techniques in the flute such as flutter tongue, keyclicks, jet whistle, tongue stop. This would result in making the adaptation sound (in the flute) as close as possible as if it had been played by a tango violinist, not a classical violinist.

Further comments

Teachers and candidates are strongly encouraged to review the music guide. Many of the issues with the submissions were the result of not following the published guidance.

Please remind the candidate that this component should be taken as a whole. The exploration made informs the creation and the adaptation. These are not independent and isolated areas, but they are interconnected.

Higher level presenting music

The range and suitability of the work submitted

Candidates and their teachers, seemed to have grasped one of the essential facets of this part of the exam—that the areas of inquiry (AOI) must be ADDRESSED in the programme notes and, for high marks, linked up well.

There were some very fine submissions of various disciplines, though very few this session, from the world music canon; most were western arts, western pop and similar, as well as music technology (part of the course by necessity).

There were very few weak candidates. There was a very small number of candidates whose recordings led to procedures to follow up on the possibility of misconduct. These are typically where there is an obvious 'cut' in the recording, or the candidate has engaged in recording-studio cheating in part C. This would be, for example, if part of a recording is 'spliced in' from another recording. Such misconduct is very obvious to examiners who indicate this through academic misconduct concerns. The consequences for the candidate may be serious and teachers are urged to guard against it.

The general standard was, however, very good, rules were generally followed and there were some imaginative and highly skilled presentations.

Candidate performance against each criterion

Criterion A

Few candidates scored fewer than 3 or 4 for this criterion. However, equally few scored 6. For a really good mark here, candidates MUST include scores—they need not be traditional manuscripts—that are relevant. They also must LINK their AOI observations to the music. Like this (purely invented) example:

'This work by J.S. Bach is sacred music, that is to say it was written for real use in Church. It therefore fulfils the object of AOI-1. It does this by quoting ancient choral tunes in its melody (see manuscript extract fig 1), also by setting the sacred text of.....(see fig 2), as well as being specifically written for.....when the composer was.....The work can also be performed in a secular context, but the primary reason for its existence is as sacred repertory, hence AOI-1'

Many candidates engaged in rather pointless personal reminiscences and personal points. Occasionally such writing might be appropriate, but the word count is far better used in describing the music and how it links up. Writing in the third person present or past tense (as appropriate) will often discourage personal reminiscences and engender the style needed here.

Here is a (purely invented) example of the sort of writing that does not really belong here, but which is encountered regularly enough:

'Last Christmas my cat died. He had meant so much to me that I thought I would try to write some music to get over the loss of losing Benny the cat. He had meant so much to the family and I had had him since he was only a kitten. I thought of all the things he used to do, like playing and running and sitting on my bed at night. So I wrote some music that suggested those things'

Instead, a description of the music and how it links to the AOI, with features in the music that that illustrate this link between the music and the AOI, is needed here, rather than the personal story.

Perhaps:

'My piece is suggestive of the life of a cat. Note how the fast semi-quavers could be suggestive of the fast running; that the contrasting long sustained chords, that move only a little, suggestive of the times when the cat is sleeping. Also, that the title of the piece.....and other features such as.....and.....show how the cat is loved in a family home. It fits into AOI-? Because it contains.....etc '

Criterion B

Many very good submissions – some extremely idiomatic. Candidates should guard against too much repetition (where this is appropriate—minimalist music, for example does not apply), and try (again, where appropriate—some world music may not apply) to include some sort of structure. Often candidates get a very good idea or motif, and present that, but it may not develop.

Criterion C

As in the programme that ended last year, some fabulous playing and (as is often the case in November) very little weak playing.

Programmes should be accompanied when they need to be, for example concerto movements or violin sonatas. Backing tracks are acceptable, but, as all musicians will know, they are not ideal.

Music Tech presentations should not shew the candidate. Only a closeup of the equipment and relevant sections of the hardware on the video.

Criterion D

Generally good. Remember that scores can be marked here too as well as audio quality, general musical communication such as rubato, dynamics, tempo choice. Musical intentions, how effective the AOI are followed and transmitted as a whole are also covered.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future candidates

- Consult the music guide for correct details
- Write in the third person in A and do not include personal irrelevant stories
- LINK the writing in A to musical features in the repertoire
- Try to introduce structure in B and do not rely on repetition too much
- Choose repertoire that can be delivered accurately and well—even if simpler than other repertoire that is delivered with problems
- Do not be tempted to engage in cutting / splicing in (in C) other sections of recordings, second takes, or even commercial recordings. This is academic misconduct and is easily detected and can result in very profound consequences.